

<HTML5, De-bunked>

Looking beyond the HTML5 hype, so you don't have to

Anonymous Writer #4492
readersletters@thinkdigit.com

Before you continue, please take a moment to read the following paragraph.

~Are you excited about HTML5? Web video! On your iPhone! Without Flash! Wahey! Soon everything will be HTML5-ed, and we'll be able to liberate ourselves from Adobe's proprietary deathgrip, and everything will be open! And standard!~

If your sentiments in re HTML5 mirror the above, congratulations. You're now part of an elite club — inhabited in significant part by middle managers, "tech pundits" and morons (not mutually exclusive groups, mind) — that bandies about terms in inverse proportion to how much they know about it. See also "Web2.0".

It's not (entirely) your fault, though. In fact, it'd be perfectly reasonable for us to fill these two pages with swear words directed at Steve Jobs, and knock off for a game of ~Quake III~. Apple isn't one of our advertisers, so the people at the top would let it fly, too. But we like to think we're above that sort of thing, so here's something less childish instead.

<Where this story begins>

Rewind to five minutes before this article was born. Picture a carefree Chrome window (or tab, if you must), browsing happily through the Web. News of Apple's HTML5 demo page breaks. "Groovypants!" thinks the tab, hastening to the site, "I was made for this." Then things go a little south. "You'll need to download Safari to view this demo."

"Odd," thinks the tab, "I've got the same rendering engine; that should have worked." Skip to the developer demos — essentially the same demos, only Apple now reveals how to create them — and those work just fine. Curiouser and curiouser.

This will probably be old news by the time you've read this, but if you're not still ticked off about this, it's probably time to look yourself in the mirror and reflect on what you've done with your life.

But let's save the bile for a bit. Let's look past the irony that someone could actually say "open standard" with a straight face while locking other browsers out of the demos for those open standards. Let us, after 345 words of faffing about, start with a basic question.

<What is HTML5, anyway?>

From html5.org: "HTML5 is a new version of HTML and XHTML. The HTML5 draft specification defines a single language that can be written in HTML and XML. It attempts to solve issues found in previous iterations of HTML and addresses the needs of Web Applications, an area previously not adequately covered by HTML."

Not the most interesting definition; but what did you expect? It's concise and accurate, and devoid of all the manure that anyone else would pad that description with.



A 3D rendering of the earth, done using the canvas element in HTML5

Let's examine that last bit some more: "addresses the needs of Web Applications." Obviously, the most publicised need has been that of delivering audio and video. And, indeed, that's accurate — HTML5 does provide for watching web video and audio without plugins. In fact, the way the web's been

banging on about it, you'd probably think it's the most important thing that HTML5 does. If, that is, you were the sort of brain-dead

drool machine that spends their entire day on YouTube.

The rest of us expect a little more than the death of a few brain cells.

<The real HTML5>

One of the big objectives of this "new version of HTML" malarkey is really about taking a step towards building a ~Semantic Web~. If that term sounds familiar, it's because every tech publication and their dog has gushed about this pet project of Sir Tim Berners-Lee in the past few years, only to find out that other than us and Sir Tim gave a toss. Finally, it appears that the powers that be have stopped sitting on their thumbs, and decided get on with this "new web" thing already.

If you've ever taken a look at a page's HTML (right-click > View Source), you may have noticed that its structure is riddled with tags like `<div class="content">`, and other similar constructs, one for each area of the web page. While the generic `<div>` element is a great boon to web designers, allowing them to bend it to their will, it isn't so great for the search engines cataloguing the internet. How is a search spider supposed to tell the difference between the word "Forum" in a menu bar, and the same word inside a paragraph?



Web typography looks sexy and exciting, but it isn't HTML5. It's CSS